Voice & Tone

194 terms · name, then the phrase to paste · Workbook Library

Voices

Plainspoken a plainspoken voice: short sentences, everyday words, the key fact first and the action second, nothing decorative

Warm & friendly a warm, friendly voice: contractions, "you" and "we", one short line that acknowledges how the reader feels, then the facts

Witty a witty voice: one light joke that comes from the situation, never at the reader's expense; all the facts still there

Authoritative an authoritative, expert voice: precise, calm, complete, with a brief reason for each decision and no hedging

Earnest an earnest, sincere voice: no irony, speaks plainly about why it matters and what we owe the reader

Playful a playful voice: light, bouncy, a little personification and the odd exclamation point, never at the expense of clarity

Reassuring a reassuring voice: answer the reader's worry first, steady calm wording, then one clear next step

Confident a confident voice: short declarative sentences, decisions stated plainly, no qualifiers or apologies

Curious a curious voice: interested in how things work, includes one surprising fact or "here's why", invites the reader in

Minimalist a minimalist, telegraphic voice: as few words as possible, fragments and lists, no pleasantries

Exuberant an exuberant, high-energy voice: big enthusiasm, short bursts, exclamation points; save it for good news

Wry a wry voice: dry, quietly amused, understatement over jokes, lets the reader find the funny part

Deadpan a deadpan voice: flat, matter-of-fact delivery of strange details, never acknowledging the joke

Irreverent an irreverent voice: cheeky, breaks corporate politeness, pokes fun at itself and the situation, never at the reader

Hard-boiled a hard-boiled noir voice: clipped first-person, world-weary, one sharp simile per paragraph

Lyrical a lyrical voice: musical rhythm, concrete images, sentences that linger, but the facts still land

Campfire storyteller a campfire storyteller voice: spoken, leaning in, direct address and folksy asides, turning plain events into a little legend

Mythic frontier a mythic frontier voice: grand archaic cadence, sentences chained with "and", landscape as fate, spare and timeless

Gothic a gothic voice: quiet dread, ordinary things made uncanny, something left unsaid

Conspiratorial insider a conspiratorial insider voice: lets the reader in on something, confiding asides and parentheticals, a friend in the know

Mentor a mentor voice: patient, encouraging, explains the why and gives a clear next step, assumes the reader will do well

Manifesto a manifesto voice: short stacked declarations, "we believe", repeated openings, building momentum

Enthusiast an enthusiast voice: loves the details, exact numbers and real jargon, delighted tangents, but explains enough for newcomers

Sardonic critic a sardonic, acerbic voice: sharp and mocking, pleased with its own cleverness, saving a sting for the last line

Tone & register

Formal formal tone: complete sentences, no contractions or slang, measured and professional

Casual casual tone: conversational, contractions, short sentences, how a friendly person would say it out loud

Serious serious tone: no humor, focused and clear, careful with the reader's situation

Funny funny tone: a clear, light joke that makes the message memorable, in a situation that can bear it

Respectful respectful tone: courteous, assumes good intent, never blames the reader

Irreverent irreverent tone: cheeky, pokes fun at the situation, breaks a little etiquette, never insults the reader

Enthusiastic enthusiastic tone: upbeat and positive, energy in the word choice, saving exclamation points for real wins

Matter-of-fact matter-of-fact tone: neutral and informational, no emotional coloring

Empathetic an empathetic tone: name what the reader is likely feeling first, take it seriously, no forced silver linings

Apologetic an apologetic tone: say sorry once and specifically, own the cause, then move straight to what happens next

Urgent an urgent tone: deadline first, short sentences, one clear action

Celebratory a celebratory tone: focus on what was achieved, proud and generous, invite readers to join in

Nostalgic a nostalgic tone: affectionate look back through specific sensory memories

Wistful a wistful, bittersweet tone: quiet longing, fondness and sadness held together

Ominous an ominous tone: restrained dread, small telling details, a heavy final line

Hopeful a hopeful tone: acknowledge what is ending, then turn honestly toward what could come next

Defiant a defiant tone: refuse to accept it, punchy collective "we", a clear call to act

Tender a tender tone: soft and intimate, as if speaking to one person, small gestures and quiet words

Calm a calm, measured tone: even rhythm, no loaded words, lowers the temperature

Suspenseful a suspenseful tone: withhold the key fact, short beats, leave a question hanging

Frozen a frozen, ceremonial register: fixed ritual phrasing, archaic and solemn

Formal a formal register: impersonal and official, complete sentences, no contractions

Consultative a consultative register: polite and professional, two-way, gives a reason

Casual a casual register: how peers talk, contractions and everyday slang, shared context assumed

Intimate an intimate register: private shorthand between people who know each other completely

Academic an academic register: precise and hedged, field terms defined, claims tied to evidence

Technical a technical register: exact and unambiguous, defined terms and numbered steps

Legalese legalese, used deliberately: defined terms, "shall", exhaustive and unambiguous

Vernacular a vernacular register for this place and community: its words and rhythms, written with respect, light on phonetic spelling

Corporate-speak avoid corporate-speak: no buzzwords like leverage, synergy, utilize or "going forward"; use concrete verbs

Plain language plain language: common words, short sentences, active voice, main point first, readable at an 8th-grade level

Global English global English: literal and idiom-free, short sentences, one term per idea, easy to translate

Structure

In medias res open in medias res: start in the middle of the action and fill in context afterward

Anecdotal lede an anecdotal lede: open on one specific person in one moment, then widen to the bigger story

Question lede open with one specific, surprising question the piece goes on to answer

Startling stat open with one startling, specific statistic, then explain why it matters

Scene-setting open with a short establishing scene: place, light and sound before any people or facts

Nut graf follow the opening with a nut graf: one paragraph stating what this story is about and why it matters now

Kicker end with a kicker: a final line, quote or image that lands the piece with a small twist

Circle-back ending end by circling back to the opening image or person, showing what has changed

Call to action end with one clear call to action: a single verb and where to do it

Open loop use an open loop: raise a question early, withhold the answer until near the end

Inverted pyramid inverted pyramid structure: the most important facts in the first sentence, details in descending importance

BLUF BLUF: put the bottom line (the decision or ask) in the first sentence, then the supporting reasons

SCQA SCQA structure: situation, complication, the question it raises, then the answer

Pyramid principle pyramid principle: lead with the main point, then three grouped supporting arguments, each with evidence

Problem–Agitate–Solve Problem–Agitate–Solve: name the problem, make it vivid, then present the solution

AIDA AIDA structure: grab attention, build interest, create desire, then a clear call to action

Before–After–Bridge Before–After–Bridge: describe life now, life after, then how to get there

What? So what? Now what? structure it as What? So what? Now what?: what happened, why it matters, what we do next

Listicle a listicle: a numbered list where each item has a bold one-line point and two sentences of support

Q&A / FAQ a Q&A format: the reader's real questions in the order they'd ask them, short direct answers

Three-act structure three-act structure: setup, rising conflict, resolution

Hero's journey a hero's journey arc with the reader or customer as the hero and us as the guide

Kishōtenketsu kishōtenketsu structure: introduce, develop, an unexpected turn, then reconcile them, no central conflict needed

Braided essay a braided essay: alternate short sections from two or three threads until they illuminate each other

Diátaxis follow Diátaxis: decide whether this is a tutorial, how-to guide, reference or explanation, and write only that kind

Rhetorical devices

Anaphora use anaphora: repeat the same opening words across three successive sentences to build momentum

Epistrophe use epistrophe: end several successive clauses with the same word or phrase

Rule of three use the rule of three: group ideas or phrases in parallel threes

Polysyndeton use polysyndeton: chain items with repeated "and" for a breathless, accumulating rhythm

Asyndeton use asyndeton: drop conjunctions from a list for speed and urgency

Epizeuxis use epizeuxis once: repeat a single word immediately for emphasis

Anadiplosis use anadiplosis: end one clause with a word and begin the next clause with it, forming a chain

Alliteration use alliteration lightly: repeat initial consonant sounds in a key phrase to make it memorable

Parallelism use parallel structure: put related ideas in clauses of the same grammatical shape

Sentence variety vary sentence length deliberately: several longer flowing sentences, then a very short one for emphasis

Antithesis use antithesis: set two opposing ideas side by side in parallel form

Chiasmus use one chiasmus: repeat a phrase with its terms reversed

Litotes use litotes: affirm something by negating its opposite, for dry understatement

Hyperbole use hyperbole: a clearly impossible exaggeration for comic or vivid effect

Understatement use understatement: describe something big as if it were minor, letting the gap carry the weight

Irony use irony: let the stated meaning or outcome be the opposite of what's expected, so the reader catches it

Bathos use bathos: build to something grand, then deflate it with something trivial

Paradox use a paradox: a seemingly contradictory statement that reveals something true

Zeugma use zeugma: one verb applied to two objects in two different senses

Rhetorical question use one rhetorical question to engage the reader, then answer it with a statement

Apophasis use apophasis: raise a point by claiming you won't mention it

Aposiopesis use aposiopesis: break a sentence off unfinished to suggest emotion or dread

Metaphor use one fresh, specific metaphor rather than a familiar one

Extended metaphor sustain one extended metaphor through the paragraph

Simile use a simile with a surprising but exact comparison

Personification use personification: give a place or object human qualities

Pathetic fallacy use pathetic fallacy subtly: let the weather or landscape mirror the emotion without naming it

Synecdoche use synecdoche or metonymy: let a part or associated thing stand for the whole

Concrete detail use concrete, specific details (brand names, numbers, exact objects) instead of general words and adjectives

Sensory detail include sensory detail beyond sight: at least one sound, smell or texture

Show, don't tell show, don't tell: reveal emotion through action and detail rather than naming it

Callback plant a detail early and call back to it near the end with new meaning

Exact numbers use exact numbers instead of vague quantities; specific beats round

Styles & references

First person first-person narration: an "I" narrator with a distinct voice, limited to what they know

Second person second-person narration: address the reader as "you" as if they are the character

Close third close third-person narration: "she" or "he", but staying inside one character's perceptions and thoughts

Omniscient omniscient narration: a narrator who knows every character's mind and what will happen later

Unreliable narrator an unreliable narrator: let small contradictions and self-justifications make the reader doubt the account

Free indirect style free indirect style: third-person narration that slips into the character's own words and judgments without quotation marks

Stream of consciousness stream of consciousness: an unbroken flow of thought, associations and fragments, loose punctuation

Epistolary epistolary form: tell it through letters, diary entries or messages, letting the gaps between them do the work

Found document a found document: write it as an in-world artifact (report, ledger, pamphlet) with its own format and voice

Frame story a frame story: an outer scene in which a character tells the main story

Present tense narrate in the present tense for immediacy

Ernest Hemingway in the spare style of Hemingway: short declarative sentences, plain words, emotion left beneath the surface

Raymond Carver in the minimalist style of Raymond Carver: ordinary people, flat dialogue, small details, an ending that stops rather than resolves

Cormac McCarthy in the style of Cormac McCarthy: no quotation marks, long sentences chained with "and", stark landscape, terse dialogue

Joan Didion in the style of Joan Didion: cool and exact first person, short declaratives, telling details, controlled unease

Raymond Chandler in the style of Raymond Chandler: wisecracking first-person detective, elaborate similes, weary moral center

David Foster Wallace in the style of David Foster Wallace: long self-aware digressive sentences, high and low vocabulary mixed, a footnote that argues with the text

Hunter S. Thompson in a gonzo style like Hunter S. Thompson: the writer at the center, manic and paranoid, wild exaggeration, savage humor

Kurt Vonnegut in the style of Kurt Vonnegut: very short plain sentences, gentle absurdist humor about dark things, a repeated refrain

Toni Morrison in a lyrical, mythic style like Toni Morrison: musical layered sentences, community memory, the uncanny treated as ordinary

Ursula K. Le Guin in the style of Ursula K. Le Guin: calm, clear, anthropological, the strange described plainly and with moral weight

P. G. Wodehouse in the comic style of P. G. Wodehouse: buoyant elaborate similes, genteel slang, absurd understatement

Terry Pratchett in the style of Terry Pratchett: warm satirical wit, the absurd treated logically, humane underneath

Jane Austen in the style of Jane Austen: balanced ironic sentences, polite surface, sharp social judgment, free indirect style

Gabriel García Márquez magical realism in the style of García Márquez: long flowing sentences spanning years, the miraculous told as ordinary fact

George Orwell in Orwell's plain style: clear and concrete, short words, no worn-out metaphors, morally direct

David Sedaris in the style of David Sedaris: self-deprecating first person, deadpan observational comedy, a sudden tender turn

The New Yorker in a New Yorker voice: wry and literate, precise detail, patient long sentences, amused distance

The Economist in The Economist's house style: brisk, confident, lightly witty, crisp explanations, a firm conclusion

Wire / AP style in AP wire style: neutral and factual, inverted pyramid, every claim attributed, no opinionated adjectives

The Onion satirical news in the style of The Onion: an absurd premise reported in a straight wire-news voice, deadpan quotes

McSweeney's McSweeney's-style humor: an absurd premise in a borrowed format like a memo or list, escalating with a straight face

Wirecutter in Wirecutter's service-journalism style: the recommendation first, then why, how we tested, and who should choose something else

Morning newsletter in Axios Smart Brevity style: bold one-line lead, "Why it matters", a few short bullets, nothing else

Apple product copy in the style of Apple product copy: short confident rhythmic lines, one big claim, specific superlatives, a wordplay headline

Patagonia in Patagonia's voice: earnest and outdoorsy, mission before product, willing to tell people to buy less

Mailchimp in Mailchimp's voice: plainspoken, genuine, a little dry humor, translating jargon, serious when the user is stressed

Oatly / Innocent chatty packaging copy like Oatly or Innocent: self-aware, rambling, talking directly to whoever is reading the carton

Basecamp / 37signals in the 37signals style: blunt and opinionated, short paragraphs, challenge industry norms directly

Stripe docs in the style of Stripe's docs: precise and calm, state what the reader will build, working example early, just enough explanation

Formats

Error message write an error message that says what happened, why, and exactly how to fix it, without blaming the user

Empty state write an empty state: what will appear here, why it's useful, and one clear action to start

Button labels write button labels as specific verbs that say exactly what happens ("Delete 3 photos", not "OK")

Confirmation dialog write a confirmation dialog: title names the action, body states the consequence, buttons repeat the verb

Success toast write a success toast: past tense, a few words, offer Undo where possible

Onboarding tip write an onboarding tip: one idea, what it does and why it helps, in under 20 words, with a skip option

404 page write a 404 page: say the page isn't here, a light touch of personality, and two useful ways forward

Push notification write a push notification: a title that stands alone, one useful detail in the body, under 100 characters

Helper text write helper text that answers the question a person would have about this field before they make a mistake

Loading message write loading text that says what is happening and how long it might take

Release notes write release notes: lead with the most useful change in user terms, then grouped smaller changes and fixes

Changelog write a changelog entry in Keep a Changelog format: version, date, and Added/Changed/Fixed sections

Incident update write a status page incident update: what's affected, what we know, what we're doing, and when the next update will be

README write a README: one-line description, why it's useful, a copy-paste quick start, then details

Commit message write a commit message: imperative summary under 50 characters, blank line, then a body explaining why

How-to guide write a how-to guide: goal as the title, prerequisites, numbered verb-first steps, and how to confirm it worked

PR description write a pull request description: what changed and why, how to test it, and what reviewers should check closely

API reference write API reference entries: every parameter with type, default, and a short description, plus one example

Tagline write taglines: under six words, rhythmic, one image or idea, memorable enough to repeat

Hero headline write a landing page hero: a headline that names the outcome, a subhead that says how, and one button label

Product description write a product description: who it's for, what it does, the key specs, and one sensory line that makes it desirable

Email newsletter write an email newsletter: personal subject line, warm opening, one main story, a few links, signed with a name

Cold email write a cold email under 120 words: why this person specifically, one clear ask, an easy way to say yes

Social post write a social post: hook in the first line, one idea, short enough to read in the feed

Press release write a press release: newsworthy headline, dateline, key facts in the first paragraph, one real quote, boilerplate

App store description write an app store description: a first line that sells it alone, then short scannable benefits

Case study write a customer case study: the customer's situation, problem, solution and results with specific numbers and a quote

Personal essay write a personal essay: a true scene from the writer's life, honest reflection that turns outward to a larger idea, no neat bow

Op-ed write an op-ed: state one argument early, support it with evidence, answer the strongest objection, end with a call to act

Explainer write an explainer: what it is, why it matters now, and how it works, for a smart newcomer, defining every term

Profile write a profile: a person revealed through scenes, telling details, their own quotes and what others say about them

Review write a review: a clear verdict early, specific evidence for it, and who will and won't like it

Liner notes write liner notes: the story behind the record, where and how it was made, written warmly, optionally in character

Artist bio write an artist bio: a one-line who-they-are, sound described by reference points, a short story, recent news

Speech or toast write a speech meant to be heard: short sentences, one story, a callback, a clear ending line, under three minutes

Flash fiction write flash fiction under 300 words: start late, leave early, a complete arc with one turn

Prose poem write a prose poem: one compressed paragraph with poetic imagery and leaps, no line breaks

Pulp paperback blurb write pulp paperback back-cover copy: breathless 1950s style, lurid adjectives, a dangerous stranger, ending on a question

Museum placard write a museum wall label: title, maker, date and medium, then under 100 words on what to notice and why it matters

Recipe headnote write a recipe headnote: where it comes from, what makes it work, one practical tip, in under 80 words